Week 8 Teacher Guide: The Church's Tests: Obeying the Gospel and the Table

The Obedience of Faith, Week 8 of 12. Unit III (Testing).

Companion to Week08-TheChurchsTests.pptx.

Scripture from the NET Bible.

Aim: Answer the course's sharpest question: what specific obedience-of-faith tests does the New Covenant set for the church?

What this week must accomplish (and nothing more): the class leaves able to name the four categories of the church's tests: *entry, recurring, continuous, providential* (with the final judgment as providential's endpoint), and holding one reframe that will change how they take communion: *the Lord's Supper is a scheduled, commanded self-test, not merely a ritual to perform.* This is the payoff week of Unit III; Week 7 established that every covenant tests faith, and this week says: here are ours, by name. If the class can locate the four categories and understands the table as a weekly examination, the week succeeded.

Keep the guardrail lit. This is the second week of a unit called "Testing," and the works-righteousness reflex is still live, especially now that we're naming *specific commanded acts* (confession, baptism, self-examination). Reinforce the Week 4/7 frame at least twice: **these tests come to the already-rescued; they prove and reveal a faith saved by grace, they do not purchase standing.** The bridge logic on slide 2 actually helps here: a command is where trust *becomes action*, and it's addressed to a person God is already saving. Say it plainly whenever a face tightens.

Where this sits in the arc: Week 7 surveyed the covenant tests from Eden to Christ and ended on "salvation to all who obey him" (Heb 5:9). This week takes that "obey him" and asks: concretely, what does the New Covenant ask? Week 9 then narrows further to the living sacrifice (Rom 12): the reading assignment already points there.

Presentation

Segment 1: The Gospel Is Something Obeyed (0:00–10:00 · Slide 2)

The three bridge texts (first click). The New Testament routinely speaks of the gospel not merely as *believed* but as *obeyed*: "those who do not obey the gospel" (2 Thess 1:8), "disobedient to the gospel of God" (1 Pet 4:17), and conversion itself described as having "obeyed from the heart that

pattern of teaching" (Rom 6:17). This is ordinary apostolic language, and it should reframe how the class hears "gospel": not just a message to assent to, but a summons to answer.

The logic (second click). A gospel can be *obeyed* only because it *contains commands*. And a command is, by its nature, a test: the point where trust in the word has to become action, where invisible faith becomes a visible event (Unit III's whole theme). This is precisely how a gospel of pure grace still carries real tests without becoming works-salvation: the command comes *to the one being rescued*, calling forth the response of a faith God is already giving.

2 Corinthians 2:9 (third click): the single sharpest text in the course for this thesis. Paul says he *writes his letters in order to test obedience*: "For this reason also I wrote you: to test you to see if you are obedient in everything." Apostolic instruction is *by design* a test. When the class reads a New Testament command, they are reading a test God set for the church.

The Romans loop (fourth click). This closes the frame from Week 1: Paul's entire apostleship exists "to bring about the *obedience of faith*" (Rom 1:5, 16:26): the course's title phrase, the letter's opening and closing bookend. Then name the four categories the lecture will walk: **entry, recurring, continuous, providential.** Preview only; each gets its own segment.

Transition: "Start at the door: the entry test."

Segment 2: The Entry Test: Obeying the Gospel (10:00–22:00 · Slide 3)

The threshold commands (first click): the gospel's commands at the point of entry: confess ("if you confess with your mouth that Jesus is Lord… you will be saved," Rom 10:9), repent ("God now commands all people everywhere to repent," Acts 17:30; note *commands* and *all people everywhere*, so the test is universal in scope), and be baptized ("Repent, and each one of you be baptized," Acts 2:38). Frame these carefully: they are not *additions to* faith, as if faith needed topping up. They are what believing faith *does* when it meets the gospel's call: the shape trust takes at the threshold. And keep grace first: the command is addressed to someone being rescued, not someone earning rescue.

Luke 7:29–30 (second click): **the jewel of the week, and worth slowing down for.** Luke pauses his narrative to tell us what response to a commanded washing *revealed*: "the Pharisees and the experts in religious law rejected God's purpose for themselves, because they had not been baptized by John." Read that carefully: their refusal of a modest water rite *was* the recorded verdict on their entire posture toward God's purpose. Meanwhile the common people "acknowledged God's justice" *by being baptized* (7:29). This is exactly the shape of Eden's tree and Abraham's mountain: a concrete, seemingly small act whose acceptance or refusal discloses everything about a heart's relationship to God's word. The water didn't create the posture; it *exposed* it.

Colossians 2:11–12 (third click): Paul plants baptism precisely where the old covenant's entry-marker stood: "in him you were also circumcised… having been buried with him in baptism… raised with him through faith." The New Covenant has an entry-marker just as the Abrahamic covenant did (Week 7). **A pastoral caution:** do not let this segment become a debate over baptism's mode or precise

mechanics; that will hijack the hour and divide a mixed class. The *point* is structural: entry into covenant has always involved a commanded, revealing act, and the church's is baptism "through faith." Teach the pattern; leave the intramural mechanics for another setting.

Romans 6:17 (fourth click): conversion itself is described as a *test passed*: "you obeyed from the heart that pattern of teaching." Belief that became obedient action. That is what walking through the door looks like.

Transition: "Entry happens once. But the covenant also schedules a *recurring* test."

Segment 3: The Recurring Test: The Table (22:00–32:00 · Slide 4)

1 Corinthians 11:28 (first click). The Mosaic covenant scheduled its tests: weekly Sabbath, annual feasts, daily manna. The New Covenant schedules one too, and the examination is *commanded outright*: "A person should examine himself first, and in this way let him eat the bread and drink of the cup." This reframes communion for most of the class: from a ritual to *perform* into a test to *pass*, on a recurring schedule.

The verb (second click): *dokimazetō*: the assayer's word from Week 5's verification toolkit, now turned *inward*. The Lord's Supper is the *only* ordinance in the New Testament with a standing, repeated, commanded self-test attached, and it carries real consequences for careless approach (11:27–30: "weak and sick… some have died"). **Handle 11:27–30 soberly, not to terrify.** The point is not "communion is dangerous, be scared"; it's that God takes the covenant meal seriously enough to attach an examination; the self-examination is the *mercy* that heads off the judgment. The exam is the guardrail, not the threat.

The assembly (third click, Heb 10:24–25): "not abandoning our own meetings, as some are in the habit of doing." Frame this pastorally: chronic absence from the assembly is treated as a *symptom*, not a scheduling problem; withdrawal usually reveals something upstream in the heart. This is "come or something's wrong," diagnostically, rather than "come or else," punitively.

Forgiveness (fourth click, Matt 6:14–15): Jesus makes forgiveness explicitly *conditional*: "if you forgive… your Father will also forgive you; but if you do not forgive… neither will your Father forgive you." Conditional means diagnostic: an unforgiving heart carried to the table is a warning light on the dashboard. Land the segment: every week the covenant meal asks the covenant question: *is the faith you professed at the door still real at the table?*

Transition: "Beyond the scheduled tests, two more kinds run constantly, and there's a final one."

Segment 4: The Continuous, the Providential, the Final (32:00–45:00 · Slide 5)

Three columns build on clicks; take about three minutes each, then the summary.

CONTINUOUS: 1 John's "by this we know" (first click). One New Testament book is structured entirely as a series of tests: older writers called 1 John "the tests of life." Its refrain is *by this we know*: the **moral** test ("by this we know we have come to know God: if we keep his commandments," 2:3), the **relational** test ("by this we know we have crossed from death to life: because we love our fellow Christians," 3:14), and the **doctrinal** test ("test the spirits… confession of Christ come in the flesh," 4:1–3). These aren't tests you sit once; they're the standing evidences that faith is alive, and note, this is where *assurance* grows (tie back to Week 4's Spirit-witness: assurance rests on God's work confirmed by these fruits, not on a performance scorecard).

PROVIDENTIAL: trials and wealth (second click). The tests God *sends* rather than *commands*. Suffering proves genuineness: "the testing of your faith produces endurance… that the proven character of your faith, more valuable than gold, may bring praise and glory" (James 1:2–3, 12; 1 Pet 1:6–7): the refining fire from Week 7. And the startling one: **money is the church's manna.** Paul calls a giving opportunity a test outright: "I am testing the genuineness of your love" (2 Cor 8:8): the daily, ongoing proof of which master is actually served (Matt 6:24). The wallet is where invisible devotion becomes visible fastest.

FINAL: the last exam (third click). Self-examine *now* so the last exam holds no surprises: "examine yourselves to see whether you are in the faith" (2 Cor 13:5). And the criterion at the end is not profession but enacted faith: "Not everyone who says 'Lord, Lord' will enter the kingdom… but the one who *does the will* of my Father" (Matt 7:21), sealed by the two builders (7:24–27): the same sermon *heard* by both, but the storm reveals who *built* on doing versus hearing-only.

The summary (fourth click): 1 John as the tests-of-life book; the final court weighs deeds that *flow from* faith, not profession alone. **Keep grace close here or the slide can land as terror**: this judges the *reality* of faith, it does not swap grace for merit. Ephesians 2:10: we are "created in Christ Jesus *for* good works": the works are the evidence and fruit of salvation, never its purchase (Week 4's whole point). The one who does the Father's will does it *because* he's been saved, not in order to be.

Segments 5–6: Discussion and Close (45:00–57:00 · Slides 6–7)

Q1: "Of the four, which does our congregation talk about least? Why that one?" A gentle mirror, not a complaint session. Many churches over-emphasize *entry* (get baptized, get saved) and under-emphasize the *continuous* and *providential* (daily proving, suffering, generosity), or the reverse. Whatever the class names, turn it constructive: "What would it look like to recover attention to that one?" Don't let it become criticism of leadership or other members.

Q2: "What does weekly self-examination at the table actually involve?" The practical heart of the week. Guide toward what 1 Corinthians 11 (in context) actually examines *for*: unconfessed sin, division with a brother (that was the literal Corinthian problem: 11:18–21), an unforgiving heart (Matt 6), treating the holy casually. **Steer away from the morbid version**: "am I good enough to take this?" is the very scoreboard Week 4 removed, and it will send tender consciences into despair. The right question is not "am I worthy?" (no one is; that's why there's a table) but "am I coming in faith and love, or in pretense and grudge?" Model it briefly out loud so they hear the difference.

The close (slide 7, ~2 min). Next week: The Altar Today: the living sacrifice. Reading: Romans 12:1–2 (body *and* mind on the altar) and Malachi 1:6–14 (the blemished offerings: "would you hand it to your governor?"), both flagged. Preview Week 9. Carry sentence: the four categories in one line: *the church's faith is tested at the door, at the table, in the life, and through the fire.* Close on 2 Corinthians 13:5 as an *invitation* to self-examine, framed by grace rather than fear. Dismiss on time.

Answers to Questions You May Get

"Aren't confession, repentance, and baptism 'works'? Doesn't this contradict Week 4's grace?" No, and this is the week's central clarification, so welcome the question. A work, in the sense Paul condemns, is something you do *to earn or merit* standing before God (Rom 4:4–5; Eph 2:8–9). These commands are the *response of faith to grace already offered*: the way a drowning man "works" by grabbing the rope isn't earning his rescue; it's receiving it. Baptism is explicitly tied to *faith* ("through faith," Col 2:12) and to what *God* does in it (burial and resurrection *with Christ*), not to human achievement. The order is always grace first: God commands the already-rescued (Israel redeemed, *then* Sinai). Obedience is faith's shape, not its price (Week 4).

"Does 1 Corinthians 11 mean I shouldn't take communion if I've sinned that week?" The opposite, rightly understood. The command is to *examine*, which means confess and set things right, and then eat ("in this way let him eat," 11:28). It's not "stay away if you're a sinner"; everyone at the table is a sinner, which is the whole point of the table. It's "don't come *carelessly, in unrepentant sin or active division*, treating the holy as common." The unworthy *manner* (11:27) is the problem, not the unworthy *person*. Examine, repent, and come: the meal is for sinners who are turning, not for the already-perfect.

"Matthew 7:21 says not everyone who says 'Lord, Lord' is saved: how can I have assurance?" Look at *who* Jesus is describing: people who called him Lord while working "lawlessness" (7:23): profession with no corresponding life, "Lord, Lord" that never became "the will of my Father." The verse is a warning against *empty profession*, not against assurance for genuine faith. Assurance comes exactly where 1 John locates it (this week's continuous tests): do I obey, do I love, do I hold the truth (not perfectly, but *really*)? Those fruits, plus the Spirit's witness (Rom 8:16, Week 4), are how a true believer knows. The person who *worries* about this is usually not the person Jesus is warning about; the lawless were serenely confident.

"Which is more important: entry (baptism) or the continuous life?" A false choice; Scripture insists on both, and neglecting either is dangerous. Entry without the continuing life is the seed on rocky ground: a start with no root (Matt 13:20–21). The continuing life without a real entry is trying to bear fruit without being grafted in. The four categories aren't ranked; they're the *whole shape* of a tested faith across a lifetime: born at the door, fed at the table, proven in the living, refined through the fire.

"Isn't calling giving a 'test' manipulative, like a preacher pressuring for money?" Understandable worry, and the text guards against it. Paul explicitly says "I am *not* saying this as a command" (2 Cor 8:8); he refuses to coerce; he *invites*, and names the giving as

an *opportunity* for love to prove itself genuine. The test isn't manipulation *toward* the church's coffers; it's a mirror showing the giver's own heart: is my professed love real enough to cost me something (Week 2's whole thesis: love becomes visible when it pays)? Money reveals allegiance faster than words because "where your treasure is, there your heart will be also" (Matt 6:21). The test is for the giver's clarity, not the fundraiser's leverage.

Prep Checklist

- [ ] Read Luke 7:24–35 whole: the Pharisees-rejected-baptism verdict needs its context to land
- [ ] Read 1 Corinthians 11:17–34 entire: the *division at Corinth* is what "examine yourselves" originally addressed
- [ ] Read 1 John looking for the "by this we know" refrains (2:3; 3:14, 19, 24; 4:13; 5:2): there are more than three
- [ ] Reread Ephesians 2:8–10 so you can answer the "isn't this works?" question crisply
- [ ] Decide, in advance, how you'll model healthy (not morbid) table self-examination out loud
- [ ] Rehearse the four-category structure so the class can repeat it; it's the week's retention goal
- [ ] Print/post next week's reading with both flags (body-and-mind, the governor test)

If You Run Long

Cut in this order: compress the three bridge texts on slide 2 to two (keep 2 Thess 1:8 and Rom 6:17); trim the Colossians 2 discussion on slide 3 (name it, don't unpack, and definitely don't open the mode debate); shorten the providential column's wealth material on slide 5 to the 2 Cor 8:8 quote alone. **Never cut:** Luke 7:29–30 (the jewel), the *dokimazetō* self-examination on slide 4, the grace-anchor on slide 5's summary, or the four-category naming. If discussion must shrink, keep Q2: the practical "what am I examining for?" question is what changes how people take communion next Sunday, which is the week's most tangible fruit.